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Graphic Geopolitics: An Interview with Comics Artist Joe Sacco

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ABSTRACT
Joe Sacco is best known for works that blend journalism with the format and structure of comic books. Sacco's prior work has considered themes of political conflict, legacies of violence, and marginalization across a range of geographic contexts, including Bosnia, the Middle East, and the United States. This interview, conducted by the authors with Joe Sacco on 16 November 2015, explores these and other themes in an attempt to situate the positionality and choices of the creator of geopolitical narratives in the broader literature on critical geopolitics. We consider the themes of subject, representation, audience response, and stylistic influences, among others, in our conversation.

Introduction

Popular geopolitics is a vibrant subfield within the wider enterprise of political geography. An initial focus on mainstream media – including blockbuster films, newspapers, and comic books – has progressed to consider how audiences engage with and respond to geopolitical narratives, among other lines of research.[1] The audience is frequently positioned as an assemblage, whether as moviegoers who collectively translate popular film into popular culture or as the imagined adolescent male readership of comic books.[2] On film, Dittmer and Dodds write that the audience as a collective is "constantly becoming something new, as affects and meanings ripple through it".[3] More generally, the evolution of work on popular geopolitics acknowledges the productive synergy of audience response with other threads in human geographic thought – specifically feminist geopolitics and non-representational theory – to consider how affect, emotion, and performativity condition responses to popular media.[4]

If we are interested in how audiences receive and interpret geopolitical narratives, the intentionality of the creator is a necessary counterpoint. Like an author, a comics creator uses and recombines texts and narrative conventions but also makes a set of choices about the method and technique of visual representation; choices that translate into a legible media format. Readers, in

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turn, engage with the work through a set of shared textual and visual literacies.[5] Dittmer and Larsen argue that there is "meaning in the interplay and tension between creator and audience, which is particularly visible in a serial narrative such as a comic book".[6] We agree that authorial intent has particular relevance to the comics format, where the conspicuous methods of shaping a narrative allow the author to engage both textually and visually with the contingent and situated readings of individuals. It is this ability for comics to reach a wider audience, we argue, that makes them so salient for understanding geopolitical narratives across ideological, cultural, and linguistic divides.[7]

Questions of creative intent have not been pursued in prior work in critical geopolitics that foregrounds the role of the creator. In his work on Ridley Scott's movies, Dalby emphasises the fashioning of worlds through technologies of film production, as well as the representation of the warrior in post-9/11 film. He disclaims any attempt to '[impute] particular motives to Scott,' but rather works to identify commonalities in themes across three of the director's movies (*Gladiator, Black Hawk Down*, and *The Kingdom of Heaven*) and identifies the interplay between warrior and empire, occident and orient, and known and unknown that emerges in each film.[8] Other scholars of popular geopolitics have relied on secondary sources – that is, interviews conducted by a third party – to glean the intent of the creator. Dittmer's work on *Captain America* comic books most directly engages with the approach endorsed here. Dittmer draws from personal correspondence with Stan Lee, one of the key drivers behind the character's revival in the early 1960s, to relate the creator's geopolitical intentions: "Captain America represents the best aspects of America: courage and honesty".[9]

Our interview *qua* intervention argues that how an audience receives and interprets geopolitical narratives should consider not just texts but how creators craft these narratives. We want to explore the concept of intentionality in the creative process. The creator brings experiences and perspectives to their work, a background conditioned by education, interest, and prior knowledge. Choices are made about style, format, and theme. And these creative choices are iteratively influenced by ex post facto interpretation and audience response. In this case, we look at a creator who researches his comics by putting himself on the ground and in the frame with the people who are the subject of his work.

Joe Sacco is best known for his comics journalism.[10] Trained as a journalist, he has blended techniques of *rapportage* with the comic book structure of dialogue, formatting, and sequenced action. He is simultaneously a journalist, comics artist, and documentarian, who relies on this hybrid identity to communicate the messy realities of the geopolitical event. His work has focused on the Bosnian war, the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, and exploitation in America's economy, among other themes. This work challenges the narrative progression of the comics format through the insertion of historical interlude and other representational techniques.[11] Building on this consideration of technique, the literature on Sacco's work in critical geopolitics has further considered themes of

positionality and representation, specifically his self-reflection on the journalistic process in a war zone and the use of maps and abstract mappings in the visual negotiation of space.[12] Prior interpretations of his work, however, give incomplete consideration of Sacco's own perspective, relying on existing interview transcripts to inform critical readings of his structure and creative choice.

Our interest was to further explore the themes Sacco alludes to in the interview below, to delve deeper into the experiences, approach, and forms of engagement that influence his work. To build on this argument, we draw out three themes from our conversation held in Oxford, Ohio, on 16 November 2015.[13] The first section provides further background on Sacco's work, his initial choice of subjects, interest in comics and journalism, and his preconceptions of the locations he chooses. We then turn to questions of style and communication, with particular interest in representation, approach, and artistic convention. By way of a conclusion, the final part of the interview briefly touches on Sacco's self-interpretation of critique and engagement with scholarly work.

The How and Why of Where

What took you to Bosnia in the first place?

A feeling in my gut. Being originally from Europe, being a Westerner, it was quite startling to see a land war in Europe. Like a lot of people who grew up after World War II, I thought that wouldn't happen again. Nineteen Forty-Five was the year that nothing was going to happen in Europe after that – that's just how it felt. I've experienced Europe since then, I've lived in it, I know Europeans and Frenchmen and Germans getting along and all this. And then you saw this going on, and with the ferocity that was startling. I began following what was going on and it began to churn in my head and at some point I wanted to go and see for myself – again. I'd already done this in regard to the Palestinians. And it took me about a year to figure out how to get there while I was finishing up *Palestine*. Later on in Sarajevo I'd have conversations with journalists about "Why are we here and not in Rwanda?" I'm not sure that was a question any of us could answer properly except I've got to say as a European I thought it would be an easier entree to be in a European context to do a story like this. But aside from that, the war in Bosnia had been going on for a number of years so it had worked itself into my consciousness. I didn't know what was going on in Rwanda until it happened, so that wasn't on my radar.[14]

What are the ideas and preconceptions you brought with you?

I had a lot of preconceptions going in. Often you don't understand what led to the war as much as you see the brutality of the war. And what was clear is that the

Bosnian Serb forces were committing certain atrocities and were shelling Sarajevo. That is the basic premise I went in with. Of course, I've found that other forces committed atrocities. And something that's not reflected in any of my work, at some point I'll get to, I spent a fair amount of time on the Serb side in Sarajevo. So, any sort of demonising I had done of the Serbs, it was dissipated on a personal level. I realised these people would give me the shirts off their backs if they could, they've been very helpful, they're very good people in this way. But I began to try to think more about structures of why people do what they do and I began to see the influence of propaganda. Certain aspects of human nature, which surprised me, like people denying things that are before their eyes. I knew two Serb young women whose father was Muslim, whose mother was Serb, and one of these Serb young women said, "Well, my father was killed by a sniper. My father, a Muslim, was killed by a Muslim sniper". And that's all I got from her, she was so angry about it. Later on I learned that her father had been taken because he was Muslim by Bosnian Serb forces to dig trenches on the front line. She'd never told me that part of the story. So it was interesting what people selectively kept out of their stories, I think not necessarily for my benefit but for their own. That stuff's pretty fascinating.

How much familiarity did you have with the region, its language and culture?

The truth is, it was one of those situations where I was not an expert when the war began. For almost the first year I was startled by it and began slowly trying to disentangle what was going on. As a lot of people have said to me, "God, Bosnia, I can't keep those sides straight, haven't they been fighting forever?" It was received wisdom that I had succumbed to at the beginning. But you can think this through if you give a bit of time to it. I tried to educate myself and then tried to keep up on the news. But of course it's like any situation, you think you know something and then you go there and you began to find out what's really going on. I had no real concept, except for a couple of articles I'd read, about the gangs and paramilitary forces that had basically defended Sarajevo and the problems that resulted from that. I tried to explore it once I was there. Going in with a bit of naïveté, I mean basically that this shouldn't be happening in Europe, how can this happen? We say never again, how can this be happening? It was characterised in terms of genocide and maybe that word made me really pay attention.

How does your positionality as a journalist affect your comics? How did your political identity affect your ability to get the story in the places where you were working?

I have a Maltese passport, but often I'm identified as someone from the US. And depending on the situation I don't try to correct it. I consider myself

from the US in all but papers and officialdom. But I remember crossing Serb lines, like going to Grbavica in Sarajevo, which was the Bosnian Serb–controlled area, you have to pass through a Bosnian army checkpoint, then French peacekeepers, then the Bosnian Serbs. And I'd come in to a room and be asked: "Where you from?" "From Malta." "Malta? Malta!" First, either they didn't know where Malta was or Malta was something so insignificant that it was almost humorous… In the end you sort of have to use what you can to pass through places.

Other times, like in Goražde, I was thanked excessively for being an American, because "the Americans have come to save us" sort of thing. So you know I was willing to bask in that glory too… To me it's all a game. I mean I hate to say it, nationality and passports, that's someone else's bag.

How did you determine your subjects? Relatedly, how do you decide where and with whom to situate your experience of the wars you cover?

Goražde was accidental. In Sarajevo everyone had seen journalists for a long time and there was a fair amount of antipathy towards foreign journalists. I was ok with a lot of people because I was a cartoonist and that seemed different. It just so happened that there was a guy who reviewed my book *Palestine* in the magazine *Dani* just before I got there, a guy named Karim Zaimović. And he'd been killed just before I got there. So that was a strange but good introduction for people: "Oh, I read about you in *Dani*". So I was more integrated with people in the café, the rock café scene that existed in Sarajevo. But it was difficult, it was difficult getting people to talk, they were tired of talking.

Then Goražde opened up. It was basically forced to open up after a bombing campaign and UN convoys were to be allowed through. And by benefit of having a press pass you were allowed to join these convoys. A number of journalists had done it and I was a little sceptical – I thought, "Oh, ok, this is sort of a flavour-of-the-month kind of thing". But at some point I said, "Ok, let me just get on and I'll go for three or four days. I'm not going to go there and come back the same day". And I went and automatically or very coincidentally I fell in with some people. There were a couple of journalists I knew that were already there and they had met some people, and then I met those same people, and it was just sort of love at first sight. It was just one of those experiences where you go and you think, "Wow, these people, they're so welcoming". And I realised, the thing was, they had never told their stories, a foreign face to them that wasn't like a peacekeeper or a UN guy, a foreign face just meant the outside world. So it was like that. I mean, quite simply, it found me in that way.

Representation and Art in Graphic Narrative

Your work uses autobiographical elements. Are you particularly indebted to or influenced by any other artists?

Harvey Pekar, Robert Crumb, Chester Brown. A lot of cartoonists, even to this day, it's sort of a failing of comics in a certain sense. But young cartoonists in their early 20s, they have nothing to write about, they write about themselves. It's a good foot in the door of how to tell a story, actually.

So I did autobiographical comics. I was living in Berlin, the first Gulf War was about to start and I was breaking up with a girlfriend in America. And I did a comic about that. It's probably my favourite comic of anything I've ever done. I was already trying to think of how do the personal and the political begin to intertwine. I mean the catastrophe of the first Gulf War and my own personal catastrophe. They just were doubling up on each other. And that's what I was trying to comment on somehow.

When I went to Palestine one of the only common threads to the story is my own because it's a very episodic sort of book. Not until I'm in the Gaza section do I really settle and you get to know a character quite well. So I'm naturally sort of the thread. In the Bosnia books, I'm part of the story but – I hope – only to the sense that it's bringing out their lives in relief. There's a whole section about taking a package back and forth between Sarajevo and Goražde, you know, letters and packages. I think it would be impossible to tell that story without just saying I was asked to take packages. You don't say a reporter was asked… you're losing all the human connection and it's important to show a connection. These people welcomed me. What I represented to them. The fact that I was integrated into their parties. All that gives you a sense of the people, I think. Those stories about the packages isn't to say, "Oh, well, look at the nice things I did". It's to show that process, it's to put something about them in relief. I hope. And I think as my work has developed, it's much more based on the people I'm meeting and their own stories. If you've read my work, I think I'm slowly retreating… In Goražde I found such compelling people. They are the story. I didn't need to be the thread. They were the thread.

What does the comics format allow for that more traditional journalism doesn't?

To me, it's somewhat simple. I think people are compelled by images. Something like the Bosnian war, when I came back from my experiences there, and I was speaking to people, they were interested, but in about two or three minutes their eyes are glazing over. It's just a lot of information you're presenting to them, you're trying to be careful, you realise they don't really understand it, and they're glad you're safe and they're: "Ok, wow, sounds

amazing, but now let's go to the movie", or something. And I understand it, it just seems really overwhelming, people are overwhelmed by what goes on in the world, I think. So how do you make that – how do you tell people about something that they could probably digest if they took a breath and had a look.

So, the thing about comics, it has this very visceral impact. You open up the book, and if the drawings have a truth to them the reader is immediately in that picture. They see the architecture, they see the clothing, they see all that stuff, the background, and it sort of situates them immediately. And that's just by function of opening up the book. To me it's sort of a popular front of genres or ways of approaching a subject, this is just my way of approaching it. The one thing I think you can do with comics that's difficult to do elsewhere is take people back into the past. And the drawing hand allows those transitions to be made easily.

Do you, as the creator, anticipate any specific responses from your audience in their interpretation or understanding of the stories?

If you're subjective, I think you can't help but feel that they're going to read it and see it through your eyes. Whether they reject it or not… I think what I'm trying to do is give them some sense of my own politics; my own sympathies, let's say, are probably clear by the subjects I choose. So now if they don't agree with my politics and they decide to read the book, they can read it knowing that. And I think that's a good thing. Rather than coming across as someone [saying], "This is objective, and this is the way it is, and I'm going to pontificate". They know that I'm fallible in my way or whatever, but you're seeing it through my eyes. So obviously if you have a subjective notion of your own work you are trying to get something across, whether you are or not is a different story. Now as far as specific moments, where I think, "Oh, this is really going to make, this is emotional", I'm not thinking so much about a reader, I'm thinking often about my own response when I'm drawing. And drawing can be quite difficult. It can sometimes be easier to be in a situation and hear someone's atrocious story than it is to draw that atrocious story. Sometimes it's harder months or even a couple years down the road when I'm drawing a story I heard. Because journalism's a very clinical sort of thing. You're talking to people… you're trying to keep them on track, you're trying to get a story out of them, you're asking something specific about a specific event, most people aren't – generally, they float around. And that makes you very technical about how you approach subjects. It's not like you don't respond to their emotion or anything like that, but you've got work to do. When you're drawing, that's when you're actually trying to put yourself in that person's shoes. And so, it's not so much that I'm thinking about the reader's response, I'm thinking about my own response because it's hard to draw some of that stuff.

Are you anticipating any sort of audience reaction as a product of your inclusion in the narrative or the way that you're representing yourself?

Even including myself was not necessarily accidental but it came out of the tradition that I was working in at the time, autobiographical comics. And I didn't have any theory of comics and journalism put together when I first went to the Palestinian territories. I wasn't exactly sure of how I was doing or what I was doing. I thought of it as "Oh, I'll tell my stories about my experiences in the Palestinian territories". It came out of a first person travelogue is what I was probably thinking. When I was there, it became more journalistic just because that's the way I was trained in college.

Drawing myself was part of the first person narrative thing that I came out of. It became clear to me that there was an advantage in that. I didn't have to think of myself as some objective journalist, a concept that I started to have problems with already. And the first person, drawing myself, it's like drawing your pronoun walking around, and so the reader knows that whatever I'm seeing is coming through my eyes and not through the eyes of some fly-on-the-wall, know-all, omniscient, omnipresent god. Which no journalist is. Even though having studied journalism I was always mystified by how they got their stories. Boy, there's so much bumbling around I thought I was part of the story.

Are there any specific examples, thinking about creative choices you can make?

You're constantly thinking how much of the violence should I show, for example. You realise you can't be coy about violence, violence is violence and you should show violence. But then you know that, how much am I going to show, or have I got my point across, or have I got sick of it myself, let's say that… That's something that maybe you can't always get exactly right, but my intention is to communicate just enough. Because also, I have my limit.

Graphic Narrative and Academic Scholarship

Are you in conversation with academic scholarship when you prepare your work?

Academic work in general is pretty essential, I mean often you're reading those very dry, pretty boring academic books, but that someone's done a lot of damn work on and there's a lot of great information in there. My attempt is to reach a reader that isn't necessarily interested in these subjects. I don't use the word entertain lightly. To me, it's actually a good word. But to me, entertain means the person wants to keep turning the page.

As far as academic work in relation to my own, there's a book that just came out… The only one I started to read was Øyvind's thing, because I know Øyvind, I've met him a number of times, and I feel like he really understands my work.[15] And I like what he was writing but then I stopped somewhere and I thought, "Oh, boy, that's exactly what I was not thinking when I did that". You realise, you know, like anyone, academics have their filter, and then they begin to situate you in theoretical frameworks that you're not even aware of, you know. Post-this and pre-modern that. And you know, someone goes, "Wow, I feel like I'm part of the system", or something, so it was a little like… I'll read it one day sometime. I will read it, because who doesn't want to read about themselves, but I'm just so damn busy these days.

What is your interpretation now that you're the focus of academic scholarship?

Flattery, it's flattering. Then there's that sort of thing where I've sat in on a couple of academic conferences that are even talking about my work. And I get uncomfortable when I actually don't understand what they're saying. You've probably heard this stuff before, it's kind of a trope to talk about the way academics speak. But yeah, I mean there are times when you're thinking, "This is just over my head". I'm relatively smart and I don't get what they're saying, I mean, that's kind of like, "eh".

But then again, you know, there's some really interesting analysis too. And it's always good to sort of think of yourself in different ways. I'm doing a story about the Dene in the Northwest Territories. And I resist this notion that I'm part of some – they see me through the aspect of colonialism and everything. But when you're talking to people there, who are telling you, you know they're seeing you this way. And I'm saying, "But I'm not like that" – it's not important what you're not like. It's interesting to take a step back and forget your emotion about it and just say "Ok, maybe that's how you've got to think of yourself in relation to them". And how you have to approach it is way more delicately than in other situations.

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Notes

1. See, for example, J. P. Sharp, 'Publishing American Identity: Popular Geopolitics, Myth and *The Reader's Digest*', *Political Geography* 12/6 (1993); M. Power and A. Crampton, 'Reel Geopolitics: Cinemato-Graphing Political Space', *Geopolitics* 10/2 (2005); J.

Dittmer, 'Captain America's Empire: Reflections on Identity, Popular Culture, and Post-9/11 Geopolitics', *Annals of the Association of American Geographers* 95/3 (2005).

2. In major markets like France and the United States, comics readers are almost equally as likely to be women as men, and many readers continue into middle age.
3. J. Dittmer and K. Dodds, 'The Geopolitical Audience: Watching *Quantum of Solace* (2008) in London', *Popular Communication* 11/1 (2013) p. 89.
4. C. Dahlman, 'Masculinity in Conflict: Geopolitics and Performativity in *The Crying Game*', in T. Cresswell and D. Dixon (eds.), *Engaging Film: Geographies of Mobility and Identity* (Lanham, MD: Rowman and Littlefield 2002); J. Dittmer and N. Gray, 'Popular Geopolitics 2.0: Towards New Methodologies of the Everyday', *Geography Compass* 4/11 (2010).
5. J. Dittmer, 'Comic Book Visualities: A Methodological Manifesto on Geography, Montage and Narration', *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 35/2 (2010).
6. J. Dittmer and S. Larsen, 'Captain Canuck, Audience Response, and the Project of Canadian Nationalism', *Social & Cultural Geography* 8/5 (2007) p. 738.
7. For recent work in this vein, see M. Rech, 'Be Part of the Story: A Popular Geopolitics of War Comics Aesthetics and Royal Air Force Recruitment', *Political Geography* 39 (2014).
8. S. Dalby, 'Warrior Geopolitics: Gladiator, Black Hawk Down, and The Kingdom of Heaven', *Political Geography* 27/4 (2008) p. 444.
9. Dittmer, 'Captain America's Empire' (note 1) p. 629.
10. Joe Sacco was born in Kirkop, Malta, on 2 October 1960. He also lived in Australia during his childhood before moving to Los Angeles in 1972. Sacco earned a bachelor's degree in journalism from the University of Oregon in 1981. He turned to comic books in the mid-1980s, publishing *Yahoo*, a series of alternative comics drawing on his personal experiences in Europe and the Middle East. His first long work, *Palestine* (Seattle, WA: Fantagraphics Books 2001), based on travels through Israel and the Palestinian territories, was published in serial form between 1993 and 1995. He turned his attention to Bosnia in late 1995; this work resulted in three longer books: *Safe Area Goražde: The War in Eastern Bosnia 1992-1995* (Seattle, WA: Fantagraphics Books 2000); *The Fixer: A Story from Sarajevo* (Montreal: Drawn and Quarterly 2003); and *War's End: Profiles from Bosnia 1995-1996* (Montreal: Drawn and Quarterly 2005). Sacco's subsequent major works include *Footnotes in Gaza* (New York: Metropolitan Books 2009); *Journalism* (New York: Metropolitan Books 2012); *Days of Destruction, Days of Revolt* (New York: Nation Books 2012; with Christopher Hedges); and *The Great War: July 1, 1916: The First Day of the Battle of the Somme* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company 2013). In addition to journalistic work in Israel, the Palestinian territories, Bosnia, and the United States, Sacco has reported and drawn from Iraq and the North Caucasus.
11. E. C. Holland, '"To Think and Imagine and See Differently": Popular Geopolitics, Graphic Narrative, and Joe Sacco's "Chechen War, Chechen Women"', *Geopolitics* 17/1 (2012).
12. E. C. Holland, 'Postmodern Witness: Journalism and Representation in Joe Sacco's *Christmas with Karadzic*', in J. Dittmer (ed.), *Comic Book Geographies* (Mainz: Franz Steiner Verlag 2014); E. C. Holland, 'Mapping Bosnia: Cartographic Representation in Joe Sacco's Graphic Narrative', in D. Worden (ed.), *The Comics of Joe Sacco: Journalism in a Visual World* (Oxford, MS: University Press of Mississippi 2015).

13. The transcript below has been edited by the authors for clarity and content and with the permission of Joe Sacco.
14. The Rwandan genocide in the spring and summer of 1994 occurred contemporarily to the war in Bosnia. Though similarities existed both in terms of tactics and causal conditions, media coverage of the Rwandan genocide was distorted and generally relied on the othering of actors and events in Africa. The seminal treatment of these divergent frames in political geography is G. Myers, T. Klak, and T. Koehl, 'The Inscription of Difference: News Coverage of the Conflicts in Rwanda and Bosnia', *Political Geography* 15/1 (1996).
15. Ø. Vågnes, 'John's Story: Joe Sacco's Depiction of "Bare Life"', in D. Worden (ed.), *The Comics of Joe Sacco: Journalism in a Visual World* (Oxford, MS: University Press of Mississippi 2015).